protests[170] in Assam and those against the CAA in early 2020 reflect some of these. The original intent of the NRC was to identify and deport illegal migrants. For the BJP, this denoted Muslim migrants. Yet, lakhs of Hindus were excluded in the final NRC lists. As many as 19.07 lakh Assamese residents (almost 6 per cent of the 3.29 crore who applied) were left out of these. The rate of exclusions in the border districts with Bangladesh, such as South Salmara (7.22 per cent), Dhubri (8.26 per cent) and Karimganj (7.57 per cent) was much lower than in districts like Karbi Anglong (14.31 per cent) and Tinsukia (13.25 per cent), where Assam's bhumiputras[171] have lived for centuries.

In Assam, public unhappiness was rooted in the fact that, while CAA would allow Indian citizenship to non-Muslim immigrants, the Assam movement had been against all migrants, irrespective of religion. The Assam Accord of 1985 had also put down a migration cut-off date of 24 March 1971, the year of the India–Pakistan war. The CAA extended that cut-off by over four decades, to 31 December 2014. Faced with prolonged protests in the first half of 2020, the BJP now sought to get out of this political bind by promising to activate Clause VI of the Assam Accord, which promised guarantees to ethnic Assamese in government positions.[172] Essentially, Clause VI promised 'Constitutional, legislative and administrative safeguards, as may be appropriate' to 'protect, preserve and promote the cultural, social, linguistic identity and heritage of the Assamese people'.[173] This is more or less what the Government of India had done in Sikkim in the 1970s when it became a part of India. To protect indigenous Bhutias and Lepchas in the state, sixteen seats in the thirty-two-member Sikkim assembly were reserved for them, even though their share in the population was only about 20–25 per cent. In Assam, such a safeguard would mean that, even if Bengali migrants were to form a majority in a particular area, they would be unable to contest elections. In February 2020, a committee appointed by the Central government to implement Clause VI gave its recommendations on how this might work at the administrative level.[174] How the BJP plays this card will be pivotal for its future in the region.